

Marathi, and English as of now. Experts from Krishi Vigyan Kendra—Farm Science Centre, which provides training skills on scientific farming practices for farmers and the rural youth in Baramati, then answer the questions.

The portal also maintains a repository of question and answers. Upon registration, one gets details such as the weather forecast for the location. If a farmer cannot post a question online or e-mail it (to aaqua@persistent.co.in), he can SMS it. Industrial (agriculture-based), financial, and legal advice is dispensed. aAqua experts say that once they receive a question, they are time-bound to reply within 48 hours.

The Extras

Other than providing expert answers, aAQUA provides an online digital library called Crop Doctor, which displays images related to crop disease. Farmers can identify relevant photographs and look for control measures. A library of seasonal crop recommendations by experts from KVKs can be found under the Crop Recommendations. Even updated prices of agricultural commodities in different markets of Maharashtra, collected by the Agricultural Produce Marketing Committees (APMC), can be located under a section called *Bhav Puchhiye*.

A multilingual meaning-based search engine called Agro Explorer allows the user to search for content in a local language (though the site currently supports English, Hindi, and Marathi), and view the document in that language irrespective of the language of the original document. aAQUA's architecture is designed in such a way that it allows users to navigate and search through all aAQUA forums even when connectivity is disrupted. The information repository on the local computer gets updated whenever Internet connectivity is established.

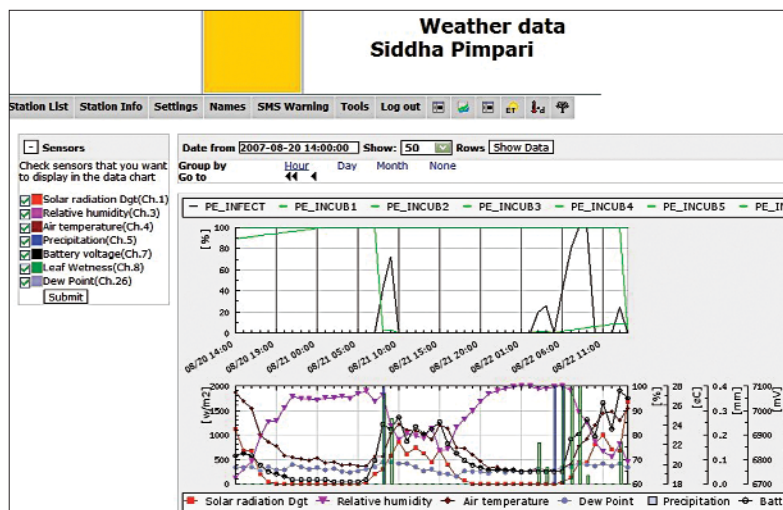
In the past year, the aAQUA portal has seen 5,760 posts and about 6 lakh views. From inception, questions have been received from 290 of India's 600 districts.

In Their Footsteps

Following aAQUA's success, a new social venture firm came up, based out of IIT Bombay's Business Incubator. The team behind it comprises Anil Bahuman, Dr Krithi Ramam-

ritham, Dr Kadarbhai, Dr Yogesh Kulkarni and Dr Bishnu Pradhan. This social venture, called Agrocom, goes a step further: unlike in aAQUA, a farmer need not visit an Internet kiosk for a weather update.

Agrocom realised that though aAQUA has been a success, there were more issues that needed to be addressed. For information from aAQUA, farmers needed to walk miles to get to



An e-mail report from Agrocom contains charts indicating various weather parameters ranging from dewpoint to relative humidity

an Internet kiosk; and what with villages being plagued by power outages or low voltages, making it difficult to install and run PCs. Agrocom addresses these issues by sending out timely weather reports and disease and pest warnings—to farmers and farming organisations that have subscribed to the service—using SMS text. When more detailed information is needed, Agrocom uses e-mail.

The Returns

Agrocom has realised about Rs 9 crore in savings for farmers in the past 11 months of operation. The cost per month for a weather forecast is Rs 100, and for a disease alert, it's about Rs 250. For e-mail-based weather forecasts for an organisation, the charges are Rs 800 per month per village. More than 300 farmers have subscribed to the SMS service.

